Meet D-Rex, a Giant Fungus

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Scientists exploring forests in Yunnan, China, found a giant fungus nicknamed D-rex. Its upright parts can grow 50 cm (20 inches) tall and weigh up to 2.2 kg (4.9 pounds), the largest known **fruiting bodies** in the group called **Ascomycota**.

The species, Dianjunus rex, is named for its size and the ancient Dian kingdom. It is different enough to need a new **genus** and a whole new family, Dianjunaceae.

The team found it in forests near Damaidi and Yipinglang, and rainforest near Nanbang, spotting whitish **stromata** on the roots of Chinese cork oak trees.

Unlike familiar mushrooms, ascomycetes make spores inside tiny sac-like structures.

Using a **molecular clock**, scientists compared its DNA with hundreds of fungi. The family seems to have appeared about 65 million years ago, roughly one million years after the mass extinction that wiped out the non-avian dinosaurs.

Dr Indunil C Senanayake, of the Kunming Institute of Botany, said the timing raises a possibility: after the extinction, forests changed, and large amounts of dead plant material became available, which may have created new chances for wood-breaking fungi.

Word Treasure

Ascomycota -- A large group of fungi that make their spores inside tiny sac-like structures.

genus -- A group of living things that are closely related to each other.

stromata -- The upright, stalk-like parts of this fungus that grow above the surface.

molecular clock -- A way scientists use changes in DNA to guess how long ago living things split apart.

fruiting bodies -- The parts of a fungus that make spores so it can spread and grow.

Background you need

Fungi are living things that are neither plants nor animals, and many grow by breaking down dead wood and leaves.

A fungus can make tiny cells called spores that help it spread and grow in new places.

Scientists group fungi by how they look and by their DNA to tell one kind from another.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists exploring forests in Yunnan, China, including Indunil C Senanayake of the Kunming Institute of Botany.

WHAT: A giant fungus nicknamed D-rex, the species Dianjunus rex.

WHERE: In forests near Damaidi and Yipinglang, and rainforest near Nanbang, in Yunnan, China.

WHY: Because it is different enough to need a new genus and a whole new family, Dianjunaceae.

Why it matters

It shows that even in forests, scientists can still find huge living things nobody knew about, which is why exploring nature carefully matters.

Test what you remember

1. How tall can the upright parts of D-rex grow?

(A) 50 cm (20 inches)
(B) 65 million years
(C) 2.2 kg (4.9 pounds)
(D) About one million years

2. In which group are these the largest known fruiting bodies?

(A) Ascomycota
(B) Chinese cork oak trees
(C) Non-avian dinosaurs
(D) Mushrooms in general

3. What is the species called?

(A) Nanbang
(B) Dianjunaceae
(C) Dianjunus rex
(D) Damaidi

4. Where was D-rex found?

(A) In a laboratory in space
(B) In a desert in England
(C) On the seabed near Turkey
(D) In forests in Yunnan, China

5. How do ascomycetes make spores?

(A) Inside tiny sac-like structures
(B) By splitting rocks apart
(C) On the roots of oak trees only
(D) From dead dinosaurs

6. About when does the family Dianjunaceae seem to have appeared?

(A) Around 4,500 years ago
(B) About one million years ago
(C) In 2011
(D) About 65 million years ago

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: C 4: D 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Indunil C Senanayake: He said the timing raises a possibility: after the extinction, forests changed, and large amounts of dead plant material became available, which may have created new chances for wood-breaking fungi.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):